

of a compromise, but the battery life makes up for that. The Gigabyte N211U and ACi Elite have older processors based on the Sonoma platform—Pentium M processors. When it came to storage, ASUS dished out the goodies at 120 GB, followed by Compaq with 100 GB—enough to make you want to put your iPod in cold storage!

The Frills

The Sony VAIO TX37GP has an AV mode that lets you play media files without booting into the OS. The fingerprint scanner completes the features a potential buyer should look for. Fujitsu's Q2010 comes with an extra battery, the versatile dock, and a fingerprint scanner as well. Compaq, not to be left behind, bundled a touchpad deactivator—it's one critical component that a laptop should have, and on an ultra-portable, it's a must!

Performance Applications

No points for guessing the winner—the ASUS U5F, of course! The no-compromise hardware configuration made sure the competition was left biting the dust. The Acer TravelMate 3012 returned the second-best overall scores. MSI and Zenith were tied for third spot. A point to note here is the equivalent performance on the AMD Turion processor, which the MSI MegaBook proudly boasts of.

Between the Sony VAIO and the Fujitsu, Sony climbs higher on our performance scale, simply because of its stunning battery life. The Compaq B1900, based on an ATI chipset, seems to lack steam—the platform seems unable to match the Intel 945 chipset.

Both Gigabyte and ACi, based on the older Pentium M hardware, could hardly match the new configurations on other ultra-portables—it wouldn't be fair to compare them with the rest.

Battery life

The most important parameter of them all, battery life is where ultra-portable buyers have their eyes keenly set. The Sony VAIO TX37GP



The Acer TravelMate 3012—mobility without compromises

went on for 369 minutes—a little over six hours—playing our DVD video file; expect even better life when working with daily applications. The ACi Elite was next with a little over three hours, followed by Zenith, MSI and Acer—all separated by just a hairsbreadth.

Our Conclusion

Traditionally, ultra-portable laptops commanded a high premium, and fewer players meant consumers had few options. Not anymore! The ACi Elite, for example, is priced at an unbelievable Rs 38,000.

Taking all three parameters—Features, Performance, and Price into account, the ASUS U5F came out on top, thanks largely to its superb performance and reasonable price for the configuration on offer. Acer's TravelMate 3012WTMi came in second, running up in performance and boasting a good feature bundle.

Comparing the Sony VAIO and Fujitsu Q2010 with the rest would be unfair. While their performances are above average, the flaunt value these stylish notebooks offer is unbeatable; if you're one of those who want style and can shell out the dough, we say buy them!

Zenith's Presidio is a steal! It just lost out on second place due to its anaemic 256 MB of memory—bump it to 512 MB, and it will definitely give the Acer TravelMate a run for its money. If you are in no mood to spend Rs 80,000 on the Acer, the Zenith is the way to go.

KINGS OF THE RING

If you ever thought laptops were only for well dressed, sober-looking gentlemen running nothing beyond Excel and PowerPoint, you'd be wrong! There are plenty of laptop powerhouses that boast of features not even seen on Desktop PCs. Yes, you heard right; we even have a laptop with a Blu-ray disc writer!

We looked at eight machines in the performance segment—the Dell latitude D820, Toshiba's Qosimo F20, LG's LW60 Express, the MSI MegaBook 1034, ACi Matric 1400, the HP Pavilion dv8216TX, and the real stunner—the Sony VAIO AR18GP.

Features Look and Feel

Sony's VAIO AR18GP is one exceptional performance machine. Oozing bleeding-edge technology from every corner, it has the looks to put a Miss World to shame. This lustrous dark beauty exudes quality, and its monstrous proportions sets it apart from the crowd. A sensible touch of chrome adds a "bling" factor to the otherwise all-black body.

The milky-white Toshiba Qosimo F20 stands at the other end of the spectrum. Though monstrous in its own right, the Toshiba is still dwarfed by the Sony. Its white apparel aside, the Qosimo does exude a "built-to-last" feel.

HP's dv8000 has been around for some time now, and it created some amount of flutter when it was launched a year and a half ago. Its dimensions are similar to the Sony, but is rather conservative in its styling—the boring silver-grey outfit doesn't do the HP justice. On the inside, it's a

Decision Maker		Laptops
Segment	Usage	Solution
Students	Word processing, surfing, and casual gaming. Budget-conscious	Acer TravelMate 2428, Acer Aspire 5551, Compaq Presario V6102AUU
Professionals	Good performance, impressive looks, and portability. Price no bar	ASUS V6000J, ASUS U5F, Dell Latitude D820
Enthusiasts	Best performance and good upgradability. Price—what's that?	Sony VAIO AR18GP, HP Pavilion dv8216TX